THE FOURTH BATTLE OF SYRACUSE

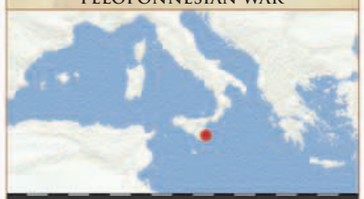
In 415 the Athenians dispatched a seaborne expedition to attack the city of Syracuse in Sicily. In the spring of the following year they laid siege to the city, with their ships in the Grand Harbor. By fighting the Athenians in the enclosed waters of the harbor, the Syracusans could deny them the room to maneuver their light, agile triremes in the manner that had won so many naval battles. Also, the Syracusans reinforced the bows of their galleys—following the example of the Corinthians at Naupactus—so they could smash the hulls of the lighter Athenian vessels in a head-on collision.

While the Athenians had the worse of naval encounters within the harbor, they were also defeated in their efforts to enforce a blockade of the city by land. By late summer 413 Syracuse had become a trap for the Athenians from which they needed to escape either by land or sea. Their commander Nicias fatally hesitated, influenced by bad omens. By the time he decided to abandon the siege, the Syracusans had blocked the exit from the harbor with a line of galleys and smaller craft, leaving only a narrow passage clear.

Having decided on a breakout, the Athenians packed their ships with infantry and headed for the passage out of the harbor. The Syracusans had warships covering the passage and others in an arc to both sides. As the Athenians tried to smash through the blockade, the Syracusans fell on them from all sides and a general mêlée ensued. According to Thucydides, "never did so many ships fight in so small a space." Triremes rammed and counter-rammed, becoming inextricably entwined; javelins, arrows, and stones showered onto decks; soldiers clashed in hand-to-hand combat. The Athenians tried to use grappling hooks but the Syracusans had covered the prows and other upper parts of their ships with hides so the hooks would not grip. After a long, hard fight the Athenians broke. Many of their galleys were lost and the rest driven back to shore. They still had more ships than their enemies, but their sailors were demoralized and a further breakout was not attempted. Instead, their troops tried to escape overland, but the entire force was captured. Those who were not executed were sold into slavery.



Hoplite helmet
Soldiers in the Greek city-states of southern Italy and Sicily wore helmets in the ornate so-called "Chalcidian" style.



PELOPONNESIAN WAR

FOURTH BATTLE OF SYRACUSE

Date	September 9, 413 BCE
Location	Grand Harbor, Syracuse, Sicily
Result	Syracusan victory

COMBATANTS

ATHENS AND ALLIES	SYRACUSE AND ALLIES

COMMANDERS

Nicias	Gylippus

FORCES

Ships: c.110	**Ships:** c.70

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** c.50	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** c.20

Beached triremes
Fighting a sea battle in Syracuse harbor ended in disaster for the Athenian ships. When forced to disembark, sailors and soldiers alike were easy prey for the Syracusan troops on the shore.